PREFACE

"Ballistic missile threat inbound to Hawaii. Seek immediate shelter. This is not a drill," said a text message received by tens of thousands of Hawaii residents on the morning of January 13, 2018. "First instinct was to jump out of bed and figure out what was going on," recalled Luke Clements, a twenty-one-year-old college sophomore and football player at the University of Hawaii at Manoa. The basement classroom where Clements found temporary refuge was soon full of people. Some were screaming, demanding that the door be closed. "For a good 10 minutes, there were no rules. Everyone was trying to survive together," recalled Clements. "It was a calm chaos."

The message turned out to be a false alarm. As the authorities would later say, someone had pushed the "wrong button." In fact, the story was more complicated. The official who made the mistake was a ten-year veteran of the emergency agency and had to push not one but two buttons to activate the alert that caused panic all over the state. The missile alert that sent Clements, his classmates, and a good part of the population of Hawaii in search of nonexistent shelters and eventually into the basements of buildings did not come completely out of the blue. The Hawaii authorities began to test their sirens in December 2017 for the first time in thirty years; the previous test had been back in 1987.[1]